along the Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand borderlands. In the eastern sector, China lays claim to all of Arunachal Pradesh (Zangnan or 'South Tibet' in Chinese parlance). In total, the conflict has come to be about 130,000 square kilometres of territory – 36,000 in the west, 2000 in the middle sector, and 90,000 in the east.

Why should 130,000 square kilometres excite such antagonism given the continent-size expanse of India and China? The total disputed area represents about 4 per cent of India's land and less than 2 per cent of China's vast expanse. We must recognize, though, that a country – a nation – is defined by land. A society may be attached to a parcel of land for historical and symbolic reasons, regardless of its size. People carry around representations of their national boundaries in their heads from their schooldays, and it is hard to shed those images. An area may have people in it that are cultural kin with those just across the boundary line and may want to (re)unite with them. Control over land is also a sign of sovereignty. Sovereignty is the freedom to do what you want in a piece of territory. When societies liberate themselves from imperialism, they imagine they will once again exercise that freedom. Not surprisingly, post-imperial countries are very jealous of their territories and boundaries. Countries can also have material interests in a section of land even if it is relatively small. The land may have valuable natural resources – oil and gas, minerals, forests, and water. It may be important by virtue of its geostrategic location – for example, as a buffer zone against a powerful rival neighbour or a connecting zone between two larger parts of national territory. It could also be a crucial basing area for the military.

In the case of India and China, all these apply, in some measure – it would be another book to describe all the meanings that Indians and Chinese associate with their territorial possessions. But it is worth underlining the military-strategic interests. In the western sector, between 1951 and 1957, China built a road from Xinjiang to Tibet across Aksai Chin, at a time when Beijing's political and military control over Tibet was tenuous. The road was vital in allowing the Chinese military to move men and supplies from bases in Xinjiang to reinforce its Tibetan garrisons. India